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Words and the Dogon world

Author(S): Calame-Griaule, Geneviève, LaPin, Deirdre

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Section Title(S): Notes

39. A minor observation will illustrate this. Once, some young girls, gathered together for a tape recording of songs called p[unknown]lu sàý, took a far more demanding attitude toward the "dash" given their efforts than male musicians and informants. (This attitude has also often been observed in the women of neighboring populations.) Ambara and Amadigné, who both vehemently affirm man's superiority over woman, sighed hopelessly at this and made remarks such as, "Just as we told you, women are not like men. They are demanding, especially when they are young and pretty. You always have to do what they want..."

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40. I will only touch here upon the psychological aspects of the mask tradition and not on either its social or religious implications, which are enormous.

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41. I have already spoken of this mask in connection with "speech of the biting of the ark," Part II, Chapter 2.

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42. I do not want to suggest that the mask custom was created to this end, but that it has been used in this way more or less constantly by male society. A well-known myth version tells of a woman first discovering the fibers of the

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dance costumes and the men taking them from her and then frightening other women with them.

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43. This description holds for the Sanga region. I cannot at this time confirm its existence elsewhere.

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44. For a description of the real costumes see Griaule 1938b. Two women beat the dance rhythms, with more or less competence; usually they merely begin the rhythms and then get two young men with whom they have joking relationships to carry it on by offering them beer. This is the only time when women touch the men's drums (see Calame-Griaule and Calame 1957:18).

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